

Manager's Guide to Tough Conversations

Difficult conversations are part of leading people. This simple framework helps your managers handle feedback, conflict and performance chats with confidence and fairness.

Before the conversation

- Be clear on the single outcome you want.
- Stick to specific facts and examples, not labels.
- Choose a private setting and enough time.
- Assume good intent — go in curious, not accusing.

A simple structure (the 4 A's)

- **Ask** — open with a question and listen first.
- **Acknowledge** — reflect what you heard.
- **Align** — agree on the issue and the goal.
- **Act** — set clear next steps and a follow-up date.

Phrases that help

- “I’ve noticed... and I wanted to understand what’s going on.”
- “Help me see it from your side.”
- “Here’s the impact it’s having...”
- “What support would help you get there?”

After the conversation

- Summarise agreements in writing.
- Follow up when you said you would.
- Recognise improvement early and specifically.